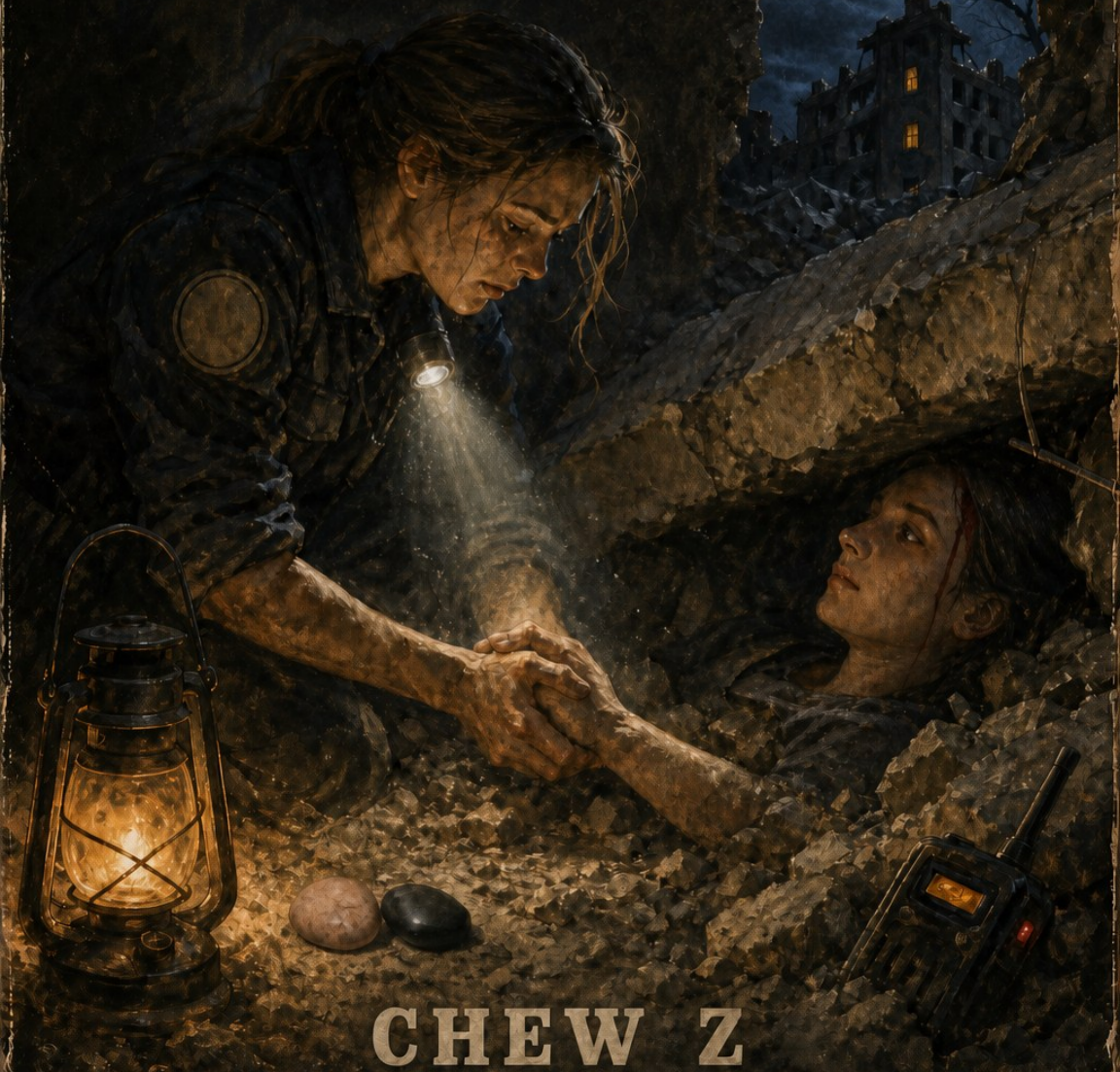


ROYA
PUBLICATION
No. 11

THE MARRIAGE OF STONES



CHEW Z

• A ROYA PUBLICATION •

THE MARRIAGE OF STONES

CHEW Z

Printed in the Reach

Roya Publication No. 11

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events or locales is entirely coincidental.

Copyright © 2026 Chew Z
All rights reserved.

ISBN 979-8-952790-10-0

Roya Publications
Publication No. 11

Typeset in DejaVu Serif.

Printed in the Reach



1



2



TWO PAIRS. ONE INHERITED, ONE ASSEMBLED.
THE DIFFERENCE IS THE WHOLE PRACTICE.

SYNOPSIS

Reyhan does not experience time in order any more. Cold stone against skin, a stranger's grip, a certain slant of afternoon light — each is a trapdoor back to some other year of her life. She has built a private discipline around the dislocation: teaching the powerful and the damaged a total literacy in their own bodies, using paired stones, one rose and one black, as instruments as precise as a stethoscope.

What none of her clients know, because she has never once said it out loud, is that the stones are not a therapy. They are a clock. Since the night a building came down on her she has not been able to tell warm from cold with any reliability, and her sense of when she is went out with it, and she presses a stone to her skin to find out what year it is.

Forty minutes of that night are the spine of everything she has built since. She spent them lying on her front in the wreckage with her arm through a gap in the concrete, holding the hand of an old woman she had never met, who knew exactly what was happening to her and talked about the weather.

Eight years later, a client asks her a question she has never answered, and her hands go cold before she understands why.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

There is a phrase that has become common shorthand in trauma research: the body keeps the score. I did not set out to illustrate a textbook, but the idea kept returning to me while I wrote this book — that what happens to us does not stay in the past the way memory pretends it does. It lodges. It waits in the tissue, in the reflexes, in the places we stop letting ourselves feel. Time, for the traumatised, is not a line. It is a loop with trapdoors.

That idea owes an obvious debt to Kurt Vonnegut, whose *Slaughterhouse-Five* taught a generation of readers that some experiences are too large for chronology — that a person can become unstuck from time not as a fantastical device but as the truest way to describe what it feels like to survive something. I wanted to write a trauma story that moved the way trauma actually moves: sideways, backward, arriving uninvited.

What I did not expect, when I started, was how much of the book would turn out to be about bookkeeping. Not the metaphor — the literal thing. If the body keeps the score, then it is keeping a record, and a record implies a filing system, and a filing system can be corrupted. Reyhan's is. Hers files by temperature, and the index is broken, and the whole apparatus she built afterward is a workaround for a piece of damaged equipment she has never once described honestly to another person.

The other thing I did not expect was how long the forty minutes would take to write. I had assumed the collapse was the engine and the rest was the book. It turned out to be the reverse. Most of what happens down there is nothing — waiting, shifting a numb arm, the weather, a song neither of them can name — and the nothing is the point. There is no way to be honest about a night like that and also make it brief. I stopped trying.

And a third: how ordinary the worst damage is. The man who trained her occupies a very small part of this book, which is not an accident. He did not break her. He did something smaller and more

common, which is that he found a woman who had already built something out of her own wreckage, and gave it a vocabulary, and then behaved for two years as though the vocabulary were the thing. I wanted him sized correctly. He is an episode, not an origin. The origin is forty minutes long and it has an old woman in it.

CONTENTS

CHAPTER ONE — NOW	9
CHAPTER TWO — EIGHT YEARS BEFORE	10
CHAPTER THREE — EIGHT YEARS BEFORE	14
CHAPTER FOUR — MINUTES ONE TO FOUR	17
CHAPTER FIVE — ALMA. BEFORE	20
CHAPTER SIX — MINUTES FIVE TO ELEVEN	23
CHAPTER SEVEN — NOW	26
CHAPTER EIGHT — ALMA. THE DAY	28
CHAPTER NINE — MINUTES TWELVE TO NINETEEN	31
CHAPTER TEN — THE APPRENTICESHIP	34
CHAPTER ELEVEN — MINUTES TWENTY TO TWENTY-SIX	35
CHAPTER TWELVE — NOW	38
CHAPTER THIRTEEN — MINUTES TWENTY-SEVEN TO THIRTY-THREE	39
CHAPTER FOURTEEN — ALMA. WHAT SHE DOES NOT SAY	42
CHAPTER FIFTEEN — MINUTE THIRTY-FOUR	44
CHAPTER SIXTEEN — MINUTES THIRTY-FIVE TO FORTY	45
CHAPTER SEVENTEEN — ALMA. THE LAST OF IT	47
CHAPTER EIGHTEEN — THE APPRENTICESHIP	50
CHAPTER NINETEEN — SEVEN YEARS BEFORE	51
CHAPTER TWENTY — NOW	54
CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE — NOW	56
CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO — NOW	58

CHAPTER ONE

Now.

The room is not what people expect. No incense, no silk, no candlelight arranged for effect. A single lamp, amber-shaded, throws a low light across a floor mat and two cushions. On a low table between them: a lacquered box, and inside it, wrapped in undyed linen, two stones.

Reyhan does not speak first. She has learned that the first person to speak in this room is the one still performing a self they have not finished building. She lets the client sit. Lets him notice the silence has weight. Most people, faced with quiet this total, start negotiating with it — filling it, apologising to it. He does neither. He simply waits her out, the way a man waits out a market he intends to buy.

She likes him already. She distrusts liking him. Both are useful information.

"You said on the phone you wanted to understand your own body," she says. "Not increase pleasure. Understand it."

"Aren't those the same thing?"

"No. One is furniture. The other is architecture."

He almost smiles.

She opens the box and takes out the black stone, and before she hands it to him she does what she always does, which is press it flat against the inside of her own left wrist for the length of one breath. He takes this for ceremony. Every client takes it for ceremony. It is the only genuinely functional gesture in the entire session and it has nothing to do with him.

Cold. Good. It is still this year.

CHAPTER TWO

Eight years before.

There is a version of this job that exists on television, and Reyhan has never once worked it.

The real one is twelve hours long and mostly consists of old people who have fallen over. Not dramatically. Not down stairs. They have got up in the night and gone sideways at the edge of a rug and been on the floor since four in the morning, and the thing that frightens them is not the hip, it is that nobody came for nine hours and they had time to do the arithmetic on that.

After the falls: chest pain that is not chest pain, four times a shift. A man in a car park who is certain he is dying and is having a panic attack, which is its own kind of dying and gets the same voice from her either way. Diabetics. Drunks with a head wound who want to fight and then want to cry and then want their mother. Somebody's asthma. Somebody's back. A child with a bean in its nose.

And then, perhaps twice a month, the thing the job is named after.

Reyhan is thirty-one and has been doing this for eleven years, which makes her old in a trade that burns people at about seven. She is not a person who wanted to save lives. She has never once used that phrase, and distrusts anyone who does, in the specific way you distrust a man who tells you at a party that he is honest. What she is, is calm at a rate that other people find unusual, and what she discovered at twenty — on a kerb, with a stranger's blood going into the drain and four people shouting and her own hands doing the right thing without consulting her — is that being calm is a physical skill and not a moral one, and that she had it, and that it was worth something.

Her hands are what she is known for.

This is not vanity. It is the actual thing her colleagues say when her name comes up, and it is said the way you would say that someone is tall. She can find a vein in the back of an ambulance at night in the rain in an arm that has been comprehensively ruined by twenty years of not looking after itself, on the first attempt, while talking

about something else. She has done it four hundred times. She does not know how she does it and has never been able to teach it, which has embarrassed her on two occasions in front of students.

The other thing her hands do is more useful and less discussed. At some point in the first minute she will put one of them somewhere — a shoulder, a forearm, the back of a hand — and a frightened person will decide, without being told, to stop fighting. She has never planned this. It is closer to a reflex than a technique. Dara, who has crewed with her for three years and is the only person at the station she would call a friend, describes it as her switching them off, which she hates, and which is accurate.

Outside the twelve hours there is a flat, and it is not interesting, and she has arranged it that way on purpose. Two rooms above a dry cleaner's that runs its machines until nine, so the floor is warm in the evenings and smells faintly of chemicals and other people's clothes. A kettle. A window she stands at. A man she stopped seeing in February for reasons that made sense at the time and which she has not revisited. A sister in another city who rings on Sundays and to whom she lies pleasantly.

She sleeps badly and eats standing up and has not had a holiday in two years, and none of this troubles her, because the job is a structure and she is a person who does better inside a structure than outside one, and she knows that about herself, and has made her peace with it.

What the job selected for in her, and she has worked this out and does not much like it, is not courage and is not compassion. It is a very high tolerance for being needed by people who will not remember her.

She has been thanked perhaps forty times in eleven years. That is not a complaint about the public; it is arithmetic. Most people she attends are having the worst hour of their life and the worst hour of your life does not come with a memory attached. She has been on her knees on a kitchen floor at three in the morning with her hands inside the most frightening thing that has ever happened to a family, and then gone, and been forgotten inside a week, and this has never once bothered her, and the fact that it has never once

bothered her is the single strangest thing about her and she knows it.

Her mother, who died when Reyhan was twenty-four, used to say that her daughter was the only person she had ever met who could be in a room without needing the room to notice. She meant it admiringly. Reyhan has turned it over for years and is fairly sure it was the most accurate criticism anyone ever made of her.

There is a version of that quality that is discipline and a version that is a refusal, and she has never been able to establish which one she has, partly because she has never let anybody near enough to tell her.

The man she stopped seeing in February — his name was Aram, and he was patient, and there was nothing wrong with him, which she is aware is the whole point — said one thing on his way out that she has not been able to put down. He said that being with her was like being looked after very well by somebody who was not there. He did not say it cruelly. He said it the way you would read out a measurement.

She agreed with him. That was the problem. He wanted an argument and she gave him a confirmation, and he left, and she made a pot of tea and stood at the window for a while and then slept extremely well.

Her sister Nadia has three children and rings on Sundays, and the conversation runs eleven minutes and is entirely composed of the children, and Reyhan is good at it, and has never once said anything true during one of these calls, and has also never once missed one in nine years. Both of those facts are load-bearing and she would dispute the second being related to the first.

If you asked her what she is afraid of she would say nothing, and she would not be lying, because the honest answer is not available to her yet. It becomes available at 4:12 on a Thursday in April, and the answer is: being in a room where the thing that is required of her is not a procedure.

One more thing, and it matters later, and nobody in this chapter has any reason to notice it.

Reyhan always knows what day it is.

It is a small joke at the station. Someone will surface at three in the morning at the end of a run of nights and say the word Thursday with a question mark in it, and four people will look at Reyhan, and Reyhan will say Friday, and be right. She is right about dates the way other people are right about their own phone numbers. She does not experience this as a skill. She experiences it as a fact about the world, like the floor being where she left it.

CHAPTER THREE

Eight years before.

The shift starts at six and by twenty past she has checked the drugs bag, argued with the tail lift, and found out from Dara that his daughter did not get into the school.

Seven ten: an elderly man, breathing, frightened, chest clear. He has been alone since his wife died in March and has worked out that if he rings at a certain hour two people will come and be kind to him for twenty minutes. Reyhan knows this. She does the full set of observations anyway, slowly, and says his numbers out loud so he can hear them being good, and this is not a waste of anyone's time and she will argue with anyone who says otherwise.

Nine forty: a woman who has cut her hand opening a tin and is more upset about the tin.

Eleven: nothing. They sit in the vehicle in a lay-by and Dara eats a sandwich he has described, with feeling, as a mistake. Reyhan does the crossword badly. A dog walker looks in at them the way people always look in at a parked ambulance, which is with the specific hope that nothing is happening.

Twelve fifty: a man off a ladder. Ankle, wrist, enormous dignity. He apologises eleven times.

Two fifteen: a young woman having the worst forty minutes of a bad year, in a bathroom, with her mother outside the door saying the wrong thing in a loving voice. Reyhan sits on the floor of the bathroom with her for a while and does not say very much and puts one hand on her forearm. Afterwards the mother thanks her in a way that suggests she has misunderstood what happened, and Reyhan lets her.

Three thirty: back at station. Tea. Paperwork.

A day. One of about four thousand.

She has, at this point, forty-two minutes left of being the person described in the last chapter, and no reason on earth to be told that.

The call comes in at 4:12.

It arrives in categories, and the categories escalate, which is how these things always go and is somehow worse than being told at once. First it is a building, which is a word that means nothing. Then it is a number of floors, which means something. Then it is a street name, and the street name is the thing that changes the temperature inside the vehicle, because Reyhan knows the street, and knows what is on it, and the arithmetic does itself before anyone speaks.

Nobody speaks. Four of them in the back doing the same sum independently and arriving, at slightly different speeds, at the same answer, which is that there is a shape to the day now and everything else has been cancelled.

They can see it from four streets away. Not the building — the dust. A pale column standing up out of a residential district on a clear afternoon and going nowhere, because there is no wind, and it will hang there in photographs for years afterward.

What Reyhan will remember of the approach is not the building. It is a woman standing on the far pavement in a dressing gown holding a bag of shopping. The shopping is the thing. It means she went out. While she was out the arithmetic of her whole life changed, and she has come back with the shopping, and she is holding it, and nobody has yet thought to take it off her.

The first hour is not a rescue. It is a queue.

They set up on the tarmac forty metres back and people are brought to them, and Reyhan works the way she has worked for eleven years, which is quickly and without commentary. Dust in everything. Dust in the packaging, in her mouth, on the stethoscope, on the inside of the windscreen. A man with a scalp wound who will not sit down because his wife is still in there. A girl of about nine with a broken arm who is completely silent and whose silence Reyhan files as the most concerning thing she has seen all day. Somebody's shoes, alone, in the road.

At quarter past six the shape of the thing changes.

A search team has got a response from a void on what used to be the ground floor, back left, under a pancake of two slabs that came down at an angle and stopped, and they cannot get to her from above without moving something they do not yet know how to move, and the gap they can get to is eleven metres in along a crawl that narrows, and they want somebody who can fit and who can work down there, and somebody at the tape says Reyhan's name, because of her hands.

She says yes before she has finished being asked.

She will examine that for eight years and never arrive anywhere with it. There was no decision in it. There was not even a pause in which a decision could have been held. Somebody said her name and her body said yes and the rest of her caught up somewhere around the fourth metre of the crawl.

The crawl takes nine minutes. She goes in on her front with a light and a small bag and no radio, because the radio does not fit, which is a sentence that will appear in three separate reports and be circled by two different people. The space narrows twice. In the second narrowing she has to turn her head sideways and push with her toes, and there is a moment — brief, unrepeatable, never described to anyone — where her shoulders are held on both sides at once and she understands exactly how this could go.

Then it opens out, a little, into something the size and shape of a bathtub laid on its side.

There is dust hanging in the light. There is a floor slab above her at an angle she does not like, caught on something she cannot see. There is a smell she recognises from other buildings and will not name.

And ahead of her and below, in the dark, at the edge of what the light reaches, there is a hand.

CHAPTER FOUR

Minutes one to four.

Minute one.

She gets her own hand out in front of her and into the dark, because that is what you do, and because eleven years have taught her that the first thing a person under a building needs is not a plan.

The hand finds hers.

It finds hers. That is the part she will be unable to describe accurately for eight years, and she does not notice it now, because she is busy, and because noticing is a thing you do afterward with equipment you do not currently have.

The dust in here is so fine it does not fall so much as hang, and it has made everything — her mouth, her eyes, the inside of her nose — taste of a school corridor.

“What’s your name,” Reyhan asks, once the settling overhead goes quiet enough for words to survive it.

“Does it matter now.”

“It matters to me.”

A pause the length of a held breath.

“Alma.”

“Alma,” Reyhan says, and files it the way she files everything — except this one, she already knows, she will keep.

Minute two.

Neither of them says anything for a while.

Reyhan lets it sit, because she has already learned, in eleven years, that the first silence after an agreement like this one is not a silence that needs fixing. It is the sound of two people finding out whether the agreement is going to hold.

Somewhere behind her, a stretcher wheel catches on debris and shrieks once, briefly, and is gone. Alma’s thumb moves once across the back of Reyhan’s hand, small, almost accidental, and Reyhan

understands it as a test — are you still there, is this still happening the way you said it would — and does not move away from it.

She runs the assessment she is not going to say out loud. Airway: clear. Breathing: fast, shallow at the top, which could be the dust and could be the chest. Colour: impossible, in this light, in this dark, under this much grey. Capillary refill: she will check it later, when there is a later, when checking it will not be a thing Alma can see her deciding to do.

The slab above them makes a sound like a chair being pushed back in another room.

Minute three.

"Talk to me," Alma says. "Not about — " She does not finish the sentence. She does not have to.

"About what, then."

"Anything. Weather. I don't care. Just don't let it go quiet."

So Reyhan talks about the weather, because it is the smallest true thing she has. Two days ago, she says, it rained in the afternoon and stopped by six, and the pavement outside her flat steamed for twenty minutes afterward, and she stood at the window and watched it and did not do the three things she had come home to do.

"What were the three things."

"I don't remember. That's what I'm telling you. I stood there twenty minutes and I have no idea what I was supposed to be doing."

"Good," Alma says. "That's the right way round."

Minute four.

Above them, work starts. Not near. Somewhere up and to the left, a long way through the stack, something heavy is being persuaded to move and is arguing about it. Every few seconds there is a sound Reyhan recognises as hydraulics and a sound she recognises as men, and between those, nothing.

"How long have you been doing this," Alma asks.

"Eleven years."

“Are you good at it.”

Reyhan considers lying, and finds, slightly to her own surprise, that she cannot be bothered.

“I’m very good at it.”

“Then I’m glad it’s you,” Alma says, and there is nothing in her voice that is trying to make Reyhan feel anything, which is exactly why it works.

CHAPTER FIVE

Alma. Before.

Her name is Alma Hallett and she is seventy-eight, and the first thing to say about her is that she would be embarrassed by this chapter.

Not modest. Embarrassed. There is a difference, and she would insist on it. Modesty is a performance with an audience in mind; what Alma has is closer to a strong practical objection to being the subject of anything. She has spent her whole life in the second half of other people's sentences — the woman who did the alterations, the one at number nine, Teodor's wife — and she has not found this diminishing, and has in fact organised a great deal of her happiness around it, and would like it noted that nobody asked her.

She was a seamstress for forty-one years. Not a designer, not a dressmaker in the sense that gets written about. A seamstress. For the first twenty years she made things and for the last twenty-one she altered them, because at some point in the eighties people stopped having things made and started having things taken in, and she adjusted, the way you do.

She is very good. This is not a matter of opinion and she does not present it as one. Ask her and she will tell you flatly that she is one of about four people in the city who can still do a proper blind hem on a heavy coat, and that two of the other three are dead. The blind hem is her example for everything. You cannot see it from the outside and you cannot see it from the inside and the coat still hangs correctly, and nobody ever says thank you for one, and that is precisely how she knows it is good work. She has tried to explain this to her son twice and both times it came out sounding like a complaint.

Teodor died eleven years ago in March, in a chair, in the afternoon, having said nothing significant to anybody for several hours and nothing at all to her since lunch. She has never once described this as peaceful. She has heard other people describe it as peaceful and has let them. What it actually was, she thinks, was administrative — a set of processes concluding in the order processes conclude in —

and the thing nobody warns you about is not the grief, which arrives when summoned, but the sheer volume of afternoon that follows.

He carried a stone. This is the detail that will matter and she has no idea it will matter, because it is not a detail to her, it is simply a fact about her husband, like his handwriting. A small rose-coloured pebble he picked off a beach the summer before they married and put in his coat pocket and did not take out again for thirty-one years. He turned it with his thumb when he was thinking. He turned it in waiting rooms and at his mother's funeral and during the eleven days in 1979 when they did not speak. By the end there was a shallow dish worn into one face, polished bright, shaped like the pad of his thumb, because it was the pad of his thumb, arriving in the same place four hundred thousand times.

She took it out of his coat the week after and has carried it since. Eleven years. There is a second dish now, very faint, at a slightly different angle, because her hands are smaller and she holds things differently.

Her son is called Mikael and he is forty-nine and lives two hours away and they have not had a real conversation in four years.

She would like it understood that there was no rupture. People always want a rupture. There was a disagreement about a cooker — an actual cooker, the one in her kitchen, which he wanted to replace and she did not — and it went slightly wrong in a way neither of them could reconstruct afterward, and then a birthday went past with a text instead of a call, and then a Christmas went past being polite, and then four years had gone by and the thing had become a structure. Neither of them built it. They just both stopped clearing the path and the path closed.

She thinks about ringing him roughly twice a week. She has got as far as the number eleven times. What stops her is not pride, which she does not have much of, and not hurt, which she has more of than she admits. It is that she cannot work out what the first sentence would be. Every version she tries sounds either like an accusation or like a woman asking for something, and she has never in her life asked anybody for anything, and at seventy-eight

she has concluded that this is less a virtue than a kind of disability she was raised into and has never had treated.

Here is Alma, then, for anyone who is interested, which is nobody: a small dry practical woman in a third-floor flat she moved into in 1974, who gets up at six because her body does, who still takes in two or three jobs a month from people who find her by word of mouth, who watches very little television and reads the paper front to back including the parts she disagrees with, who does not like being managed, who has a strong preference for being told the truth quickly, and who carries her dead husband's stone in her coat pocket and does not think of this as sentimental because she does not think of it at all.

She has eleven hours left. She does not know that either, which is the only mercy available and, on the whole, she would have preferred to be told.

CHAPTER SIX

Minutes five to eleven.

Minute five.

"Are you hurt," Alma says. "You. Not me."

"No."

"You'd say that anyway."

"I would," Reyhan agrees. "But no."

Minute six.

The truth, which she does not offer, is that her right shoulder is at an angle her right shoulder does not usually achieve, and that the position she has got herself into — flat, arm down, cheek against a surface that is either floor or wall — is one she will not be able to hold for forty minutes.

She holds it for forty minutes.

Minute seven.

Dust comes down in a slow curtain from somewhere overhead and they both stop talking until it stops, which takes longer than either of them expects. What is left drifts down in single flakes, catching what little light there is, and for a stretch of time Reyhan cannot later account for, she simply watches it fall across the small visible triangle of Alma's face, because watching it is easier than watching anything else in the room.

Minute seven.

It arrives twice. She notices, at the time, that it arrives twice. She checks her watch, which is not on her wrist, because she took it off in the vehicle, which she does not remember doing and would not have done. She decides to start the count again from where she thinks she is and to be honest with herself about the fact that the count is now an estimate.

The count is now an estimate. She keeps it anyway. It is the only instrument she has left that still reports.

Minute eight.

"Tell me about the sheets," Alma says.

"What sheets."

"You said it rained. Did you have washing out."

"No."

"I did," Alma says. "Tuesday. Two sheets and a blue shirt that isn't mine. Still out there, probably."

"Probably."

"They'll be filthy now."

"They'll be filthy now," Reyhan agrees.

Minute nine.

Nothing.

Minute ten.

Nothing. Somewhere a long way off a radio says four words Reyhan cannot make out and then says nothing further, and the silence after it is somehow louder than the silence before it was.

Minute eleven.

"What's your name," Alma says. "I've asked you that."

"You haven't."

"Haven't I."

"No."

A pause.

"Reyhan."

"That's a good name," Alma says, as though assessing a coat. "Say it again."

"Reyhan."

"Good." Her grip shifts, resettling, the way a hand does when it has decided to be here for a while and wants to find a more sustainable way to hold on. "I'll remember that."

She does not remember it. She asks again at minute nineteen and again at minute thirty. Reyhan answers all three times in the same

voice, because the alternative is to tell a woman in a hole that her head is going, and there is no version of that sentence that is worth the eleven seconds it would take to say.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Now.

The second session, and he arrives with a notebook, which she permits for exactly as long as it takes him to understand that she is not going to say anything worth writing down.

"Most of my clients," she says, "come in wanting a technique. Something they can practise in a hotel room in Frankfurt and feel they are making progress at."

"And you don't teach one."

"I teach one. It doesn't work the way you're going to want it to."

She puts the rose stone in his left hand and the black in his right and asks him, without explanation, which one is warmer. He says the left. He says it immediately, the way a man answers a question he believes is a formality.

"Try again. Slower."

He tries again. Takes longer. Says the left, with less certainty.

"Now put them down and tell me what the room smells like."

He cannot. He has been in the room twice and he cannot produce a single fact about it that is not about her.

"That," Reyhan says, "is the technique. You have spent forty years building an instrument that reports upward and never inward. We are going to find out, over about nine weeks, whether it still goes both ways."

Her clients are, almost without exception, men in the second half of a successful life who have noticed something missing and have correctly identified that it is not money and incorrectly identified almost everything else. They arrive believing they are coming for a skill. They are coming because nobody has touched them with any attention in about fifteen years and they do not have the vocabulary to say so and would not use it if they had.

She does not despise them. This is important to her and she has checked it more than once, because contempt would be easier and would also, eventually, show in her hands. What she feels toward

them is something nearer to the way she used to feel at four in the morning about a frightened man in a car park: a completely unsentimental willingness to be useful to somebody whose distress is real and whose account of it is wrong.

What she does not tell any of them, and has never told anyone, is the lie the whole practice rests on.

The lie is by omission and it is this: she presents the work as something she learned, from a tradition, with a lineage. She lets the lacquered box and the linen and the two stones do the implying, and she has never once said a false sentence out loud, and the implication is entirely false. There is no tradition. There is a woman who lost the ability to tell what year it is and worked out on her own kitchen floor that a cold object will tell her, and then discovered, by accident, with her fourth or fifth client, that the same trick opens something in almost anybody.

She charges four hundred a session for it.

She has examined this at three in the morning more times than she would admit and has arrived, each time, at the same two facts sitting next to each other refusing to resolve: that it works, demonstrably, on people who were not being helped by anything else — and that she is a woman selling the only thing she was ever given for free, in a box, with the label removed.

What she does not say: that she has asked the warmer question of eight hundred people and roughly half of them get it wrong, and the half who get it wrong are not damaged, they are ordinary, and the number is the only clinical data she has ever collected that genuinely frightens her. The instrument fails in almost everybody. Almost nobody finds out.

CHAPTER EIGHT

Alma. The day.

She is awake at ten to six, which is not an alarm, it is simply where her body stops.

The flat is cold and she does not put the heating on because it is April and she has a rule about April. She puts the kettle on. She stands at the window while it boils, which is a thing she has done every morning for fifty-one years and has never once described to another person, because there would be nothing to say about it: she stands at the window and looks at the street and the street looks back at her with nothing in particular, and then the kettle clicks.

Tea. Toast she does not finish.

At half past seven she does the washing, because it is a clear day and the forecast says it will hold, and this is the sort of decision she makes with more care than she makes most decisions, because she is of the generation for whom a dry day is a resource. Two sheets and a blue shirt of Teodor's that she has never been able to give away and wears sometimes in the flat over her own clothes, which she would absolutely deny. She pegs them out on the line on the balcony. She is pleased with the sky.

At nine she does an hour on a skirt for a woman called Ines who is going to a wedding and has asked for it to be taken in more than Alma thinks is wise. Alma has taken it in exactly as much as Ines asked and not one millimetre more, and has also, without mentioning it, left the seam deep enough to be let back out, which is the entire philosophy of her working life compressed into a thing nobody will ever notice.

At eleven she goes out for the shopping.

She is gone forty minutes. She buys: milk, eggs, a loaf, four apples, a chicken thigh, a bag of onions and — this is not like her and she notices it at the till and does it anyway — a packet of the biscuits Mikael liked when he was nine.

She has no plan for the biscuits. She puts them in the cupboard when she gets back and looks at them for a moment and closes the cupboard.

At one she has lunch. At two she has the number up on the phone and looks at it for about ninety seconds and puts the phone face down on the table, and the sentence she was trying to build, which she has been trying to build for four years and does not manage today either, is not I miss you and is not you never call. It is: I bought the biscuits.

That is all it would have taken. She is close enough to see it. She does not do it.

At twenty past three a neighbour's child runs the length of the corridor outside twice and Alma does not mind, whatever she may have said to his mother in February.

At four she puts a pan on. Not for anything — she has decided to do the onions early because doing them early means the kitchen smells right when the evening starts, and a kitchen that smells right is, at seventy-eight, in a flat on her own, a genuine and defensible reason to do something.

The radio is on. It has been on since the shopping. At about ten past four a song comes on that she does not like — not violently, she is not a woman who feels violently about music, she simply finds it thin — and she thinks, as she is reaching for the onions, that she will change it in a minute.

At 4:11 and some seconds she is standing at the counter with an onion in her left hand and a knife in her right, and the song is still playing, and she has not changed it, and the last complete thought she has as a woman whose life is proceeding normally is that the shirt on the line is going to need another hour.

Then the floor is not where she left it.

There is no sound at first, which is the part nobody believes. There is a sensation like a lift starting, and the light goes, and then the sound arrives all at once and from underneath, and after that there is a long period which she will never be able to account for and which is probably about nine minutes.

When she comes back to herself she is on her side in the dark with a great weight across her hips and both legs, and she cannot move them, and the air tastes of a school corridor.

She is entirely calm. She would like this on the record, since nobody else was there to see it: she is seventy-eight years old and alone under a building and she is completely calm, and she works out, in the first few minutes, with no instruments and no help and no particular distress, almost exactly what has happened to her and almost exactly how it is going to go.

What she feels, mostly, is annoyance about the shirt.

And then, when the annoyance has finished, the thing she actually feels, which she would not have predicted and does not enjoy, which is not fear of dying but a small, hot, humiliating flare of not wanting to do it on her own.

She has time to be ashamed of that. She is ashamed of it for about two hours.

Then, from somewhere above and to the right, a long way off, she hears a voice that is not shouting, and a light comes along the floor, and a hand comes out of the dark toward her.

And Alma Hallett, who has never asked anybody for anything, gets there first.

CHAPTER NINE

Minutes twelve to nineteen.

Minute twelve.

Nothing.

Minute thirteen.

Nothing. Reyhan's arm has begun the process it will complete somewhere around minute twenty, which is to stop being an arm and become a length of something that reports pain from one end only.

Minute fourteen.

"You can let go for a minute," Alma says. "I won't tell anyone."

"I'm fine."

"You're not, but suit yourself."

Minute fifteen.

The agreement is unspoken and neither of them will ever describe it, but it is this: nothing true gets said unless Alma is the one who says it first. Reyhan has worked out, somewhere in the first four minutes, that this is a woman who will not tolerate being managed and will tolerate almost anything else, and so she stops managing, which is the single most difficult professional decision she has ever made and takes her approximately no time at all.

Minute sixteen.

"Do you have children," Alma says.

"No."

"Do you want them."

"I don't know."

"That's not an answer, it's a filing category."

Reyhan laughs — actually laughs, down there, with a floor on top of them — and the laugh comes out wrong and dusty and hurts her chest, and Alma makes a small satisfied noise as though she has won something.

Minute seventeen.

Nothing.

A long nothing. Long enough that Reyhan becomes aware of the particular sound of her own swallowing, and of a piece of grit that has been under her left hip since minute two and which she has not been able to do anything about and will not be able to do anything about, and which will leave a bruise she finds four days later in the shower and stands looking at for some time.

The thing nobody tells you about the worst night of a person's life is how much of it is waiting. Not drama. Not a montage. Just two people in the dark, running out of subjects, while somewhere overhead men who are very good at their jobs proceed at a pace that is correct and unbearable at the same time.

Minute eighteen.

"There was a song," Alma says.

"What song."

"I don't know. That's why I said there was a song." A breath. "It was on when it started. In the kitchen. It had been on maybe a minute and I was about to change it because I didn't like it, and now I'd like to know what it was."

"Sing some."

"I can't sing."

"Neither can I. Sing some."

What Alma produces is four bars, off-key, mostly breath, and it is not a song Reyhan knows and never becomes one. She hums it back anyway. Gets it wrong. Alma corrects her. She gets it wrong again in a different place.

They do this for most of a minute, in the dark, under a building, while a woman dies by degrees, and Reyhan will think about it for the rest of her life.

Minute nineteen.

Nothing.

CHAPTER TEN

The apprenticeship.

She finds him the way people find anyone: badly, at the wrong time, on somebody else's recommendation.

By then she has been doing it alone for two years. The stones are already hers. The cold-first discipline is already hers, worked out on her own kitchen floor over eleven months of being unable to answer the question of what year it is without checking something external and physical. She has no name for any of it. She has never said it aloud to another person. She goes to him because she has read a description of what he teaches and recognised, with a lurch, that somebody has a vocabulary for the thing she has been doing in private like a woman with a habit.

He has a room with no furniture and an east-facing window and a floor he sweeps himself. He says, "Sit," and means it structurally, and she recognises the instruction because she got there first.

What he gives her, and it is not nothing, is language. Front border and back border. The idea that a boundary is a thing you draw rather than a thing that is drawn on you. The word married, for two objects that only make sense in relation to each other. She writes these down. Some of them are good. One or two of them she still uses.

What he does not do, in two years, is ask her a single question about where her own practice came from.

She notices this in month four and files it the way she files everything: irregular, worth watching, not yet actionable.

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Minutes twenty to twenty-six.

Minute twenty.

Her arm is gone. Not numb — gone, filed elsewhere, its return unscheduled. She shifts her weight a few degrees to take the ache out of one knee, without letting go, and Alma's eyes track the small movement, and something in her face, brief and almost embarrassed, might be gratitude that Reyhan is still uncomfortable enough, still human enough, to need to shift her weight at all.

Minute twenty-one.

"Tell me something you've never told anyone," Alma says.

"That's a big ask for a Tuesday."

"It's Thursday."

It is Thursday. Reyhan has been wrong about the day for six minutes without noticing, which is the first genuinely frightening thing that has happened to her tonight, and she decides on the spot never to mention it, and does not mention it for eight years.

Minute twenty-two.

So she does. Out loud, badly. Something about a smaller life, quieter, hands doing something slower than saving people, a room with a door that shuts. She does not have the shape of it yet — not really, not for another two years — but she says the vague outline of it into the dark anyway.

Alma listens to the whole thing without interrupting, which almost nobody does.

"Do it," she says, at the end.

"It's not a plan. It's a mood."

"Do it anyway. Moods are just plans that haven't been rude to anybody yet."

Minute twenty-three.

Nothing.

Minute twenty-four.

Reyhan catches herself wondering whether she turned the stove off.

She is lying under eleven thousand tonnes of a building, holding the hand of a dying woman, and some administrative sub-basement of her brain has raised a query about the stove, and will not withdraw it, and requires an answer.

She is ashamed of this for eight years. It is the single thing about that night she has never said to anyone, including, eventually, the man who will spend two years training her to say things like that to him.

Minute twenty-four, still.

The query about the stove does not go away. It is joined, after a while, by a second query about whether she locked the door of the vehicle, and a third about a message she did not answer on Sunday, and the three of them sit there in a row like people waiting at a counter, and the counter is not open, and they wait anyway.

She has read about this. Everyone who does this job has read about this. It has a name and a mechanism and a perfectly respectable literature, and knowing all of that turns out to be worth precisely nothing at half past four in the afternoon under a floor slab, which is the first lesson of the night and not the last.

Minute twenty-five.

"You've gone quiet," Alma says.

"Sorry."

"Don't be sorry, be here. Where'd you go."

"Nowhere. My kitchen."

There is a pause, and then Alma laughs — a real one, small and cracked and entirely unexpected — and says, "Oh, thank God. I thought it was just me. I've been thinking about a pan."

Minute twenty-six.

They talk about the pan for a while.

CHAPTER TWELVE

Now.

Session four. He tells her, without being asked, about his father, and she lets him, and at the end of it she says nothing at all for long enough that he starts to look for the exit in her face.

"I'm not going to do anything with that," she says.

"Then why did you let me say it?"

"Because you needed to find out whether I would." She puts the stones back in the box. "There are people who will take that story and hand you an interpretation of it, and you will feel, for about nine days, as though something has happened. I'm not one of them. I'm interested in your hands."

"That's a very expensive way to be uninterested in me."

"Yes," Reyhan says. "It is."

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Minutes twenty-seven to thirty-three.

Minute twenty-seven.

The colour has started at the nail beds.

Reyhan looks down at their two hands — she has been avoiding it, which is its own kind of tell — and sees exactly what Alma has already diagnosed herself: the colour starting at the nail beds, patient and unhurried, doing the one thing it always does, the thing Reyhan has watched a hundred times in a hundred rooms with better lighting and a chair.

Neither of them mentions it. This is not denial. It is manners.

Minute twenty-eight.

"Is it going to hurt," Alma says.

"No."

"Don't."

"It might," Reyhan says. "Toward the end it sometimes does, and then it stops, and the stopping isn't the bad part."

"Thank you," Alma says, and means it, and they both understand that the first answer was the lie and the second was the apology and that the whole transaction took nine seconds and was the most honest thing either of them has said all night.

Minute twenty-nine.

Nothing.

Then, without any lead-in: "I was a seamstress. Forty-one years. Alterations, mostly, at the end — nobody has things made any more, they have things taken in."

"Were you good at it?"

"I was very good at it," Alma says, and there is a small satisfaction in it that Reyhan recognises as her own, turned up out of somebody else's life, and which she finds she cannot look at directly.

"Say something you were good at. Specifically."

"A blind hem," Alma says. "On a heavy coat. Where you can't see it on either side and the coat still hangs right." A pause. "Nobody ever says thank you for a blind hem. That's how you know it's good."

Minute thirty.

Above them, the work changes character. It gets closer and it gets slower, which Reyhan knows is the correct order and hates anyway.

"They're coming," she says.

"I know."

"They'll be another while."

"I know that too." Alma's grip shifts again — not weaker yet, just different, like something recalibrating for a longer haul than it had originally planned on. "Stop telling me things I know. You're better when you're just talking."

Minute thirty-one.

So Reyhan talks. The weather again, because she has run out and is not too proud to repeat herself. The sheets on the line. The song, humming a few bars of it under her breath just to keep some sound moving through the space between them, because silence, she is beginning to understand, is not restful down here. It is a thing that arrives and takes up room.

Minute thirty-two.

Alma's breath goes uneven for four full seconds and then evens back out.

Reyhan counts those seconds. Silently, the way she will count nearly everything for the rest of her life, and she does not say a word, and Alma does not say a word, and the count goes into a file that will not be opened for eight years.

Minute thirty-three.

"Will you tell someone I wasn't on my own," Alma says.

"Yes."

"Not for me. I don't care. For them."

“Yes.”

“Good.”

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Alma. What she does not say.

Here is what is actually happening in Alma's head at minute thirty-three, which Reyhan will never know and which the reader is about to be told, and there is no justice in that and it is the way of things.

She has known for about twenty minutes. Not suspected. Known, in the way you know a thing from the inside, from a set of signals that do not require a diagnosis: the cold coming up rather than down, the particular quality of the thirst, and the fact that the pain in her legs, which was extraordinary for the first hour, has become polite.

She is not frightened. She keeps checking for the fear the way you check a pocket, and it is not there, and she finds its absence slightly suspicious and decides not to interrogate it in case interrogating it produces it.

What she has instead is a list. It is very short and she has been working on it since about minute ten, editing it down, because she is a woman who takes in a seam rather than cutting the cloth.

The first item on the list is Mikael.

She would like — and she is precise about this, in the dark, with a floor on her — she would like this girl to go and find her son and tell him, not that she loved him, which he knows and which would be a burden dressed as a gift, but the following: that on the day it happened his mother bought a packet of the biscuits he liked when he was nine, and had the phone in her hand at two o'clock, and did not manage it, and that the not managing it was not about him.

That is the thing. That is the whole of it. Eleven seconds of speech and four years would come apart.

She gets as far as opening her mouth.

And then she does the arithmetic she has done all her life, which is: this girl is about thirty, she is lying on her front in a hole with her arm at an angle that must be agony, she has a face like someone who takes things home, and if I hand her my son she will carry him for the rest of her life.

Alma Hallett has never in seventy-eight years handed anybody anything they did not volunteer for.

So she takes the seam in. She reduces the request until it is small enough to be given to a stranger without doing any damage, and what comes out of her mouth — flat, almost offhand, in a voice arranged to sound like a minor administrative preference — is: “Will you tell someone I wasn’t on my own.”

Reyhan says yes.

“Not for me,” Alma says. “I don’t care. For them.”

Which is true and is also the last piece of tailoring she will ever do, because the word them is doing an enormous amount of work there, because them is one person, and she does not name him, and naming him is the entire difference between the thing she wanted and the thing she asked for, and she chooses, deliberately, in the last minutes of her life, to protect a woman she has known for half an hour from the weight of a stranger’s son.

The second item on the list is smaller and she is not going to get to it for another four minutes.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Minute thirty-four.

The grip has gone slack twice now and come back twice, and Reyhan has started counting the come-backs instead of the minutes, because the minutes have stopped being reliable.

"Your hands," Alma says.

"What about them."

"They're cold." Somewhere above them a generator starts, runs for four seconds and stops. "I keep thinking you're holding mine."

"I am."

"No." No weight on it at all, the way you would correct someone about a bus route. "I've had yours since the start. You should know that. In case it matters later."

Reyhan says something back.

She will spend eight years failing to recover what it was. It had the word all right in it, she thinks. Or the word okay. Something professional. Something with one hand already reaching for the next minute.

The dust comes down again and they wait it out and the thing that has just been said to her goes where such things go, which is not away.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Minutes thirty-five to forty.

Minute thirty-five.

"Cold," Alma says.

Reyhan shifts her own coat higher around Alma's shoulder with her free hand, a gesture she knows, clinically, changes nothing, and does it anyway, because some gestures are not for changing anything.

Minute thirty-six.

"Say the song again."

Reyhan says the song again. Hums it low and off-key and constant, the same four bars over and over, because it is the only structure left in the room that is not collapsing, and some part of her understands, without being told, that repetition itself is a kind of holding.

Minute thirty-seven.

There is something in Alma's free hand. Reyhan registers this without attending to it, the way you register a chair in a doorway you are carrying something through. A small movement. A transfer. A hand opening against her wrist and closing again.

She does not look. She is doing four other things.

Minute thirty-eight.

The gaps have got long enough that Reyhan starts filling them herself, quietly, without being asked. The weather. The sheets. The pan. The four bars. A blind hem on a heavy coat, described back to its owner slightly wrong, so that its owner has to correct her, which costs Alma eleven words and buys them both another forty seconds.

"Still here," Alma says, once, in the middle of it, not as a question.

"Still here."

Minute thirty-nine.

The hand in hers is still a hand, still warm in the specific, narrowing way a hand stays warm right up until it does not, and

Reyhan keeps talking anyway, softly, about nothing, about the rain two days ago, about the sheets, about a song neither of them ever learned the name of, because the agreement was that it would not go quiet, and she is not going to be the one who breaks it.

Minute forty.

She holds on for two minutes past use.

Nobody tells her to stop. Nobody has to. At some point a light arrives from the left, and a voice she knows says her name twice, and she says give me a minute, and they give her a minute, because they are good at their jobs and because there is nothing else in the world that needs doing at that exact moment that is more important than the minute.

When she finally gets her arm back it does not work for eleven days.

Nobody asks her what they talked about. She is not sure, afterward, what she would have said. Sheets, mostly. A pan. A song.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Alma. The last of it.

It does not hurt, and she notes this, and the note has a certain grim satisfaction in it because she was not lied to for very long and she appreciated the correction.

The girl is humming. She has been humming the same four bars for some time now, badly, and she has the second phrase wrong in a way that is starting to be funny, and Alma has decided not to correct it again because correcting it costs eleven words and she has begun, without discussing it with anyone, to spend words the way you spend the last of something.

What she is thinking about, in no order, because order has stopped being available:

The shirt on the line. Ines's skirt, folded on the table, with the deep seam nobody will ever find. Teodor in the chair. Her mother's hands, which were also small. A Tuesday in 1981 for no reason at all. The biscuits in the cupboard, which she suddenly understands nobody is going to find and identify, and which will be thrown out by a man from a firm, and this is the closest she comes all night to crying, and she does not, because the girl would notice.

And the girl.

This is the part Alma has not planned for and does not entirely approve of. She has been holding this stranger's hand for thirty-five minutes and somewhere in the middle of it a transfer occurred that she did not authorise. She is not comforted by the girl. That is not what has happened, and she would want that stated correctly. What has happened is that she has become, in her last half hour, responsible for somebody. It is an absurd thing to be at seventy-eight under a building and she finds, examining it, that she would not swap it for being comforted, and that this is probably the truest thing she has ever found out about herself and there is nobody to tell.

She has noticed the girl's hands. Of course she has; she has spent forty-one years with her hands. They went cold at about minute

twelve and they have not come back, and she has been doing what she can about that, which is not much, and which the girl has not noticed because the girl believes she is the one holding on.

Around minute thirty-four Alma tells her. Plainly, with no weight on it, because she is not building a moment, she is correcting a fact. "I've had yours since the start," she says. "You should know that. In case it matters later."

The girl says something with the word all right in it, and does not hear it, and Alma registers that she has not heard it, and lets it go, because a woman who has spent her life leaving seams deep does not insist on being understood at the time.

Then the second item on the list.

It takes her most of two minutes to get her free hand into her coat pocket, and it is the hardest physical work she does all night, harder than the first hour when there was still a point to struggling. The pocket is on the wrong side. Her fingers are not reporting. She gets it out on the fourth attempt.

Thirty-one years in Teodor's pocket. Eleven in hers. Two dishes worn into it at slightly different angles, his deep, hers faint, and if anyone ever thought to look they could work out from the geometry alone that two people carried it and that one of them had smaller hands.

She does not explain it. There is no version of the explanation that fits in the time available and would not, again, be a burden dressed as a gift. It is a stone. It is warm, because it has been against her body all day, and it has been against somebody's body every day for forty-two years, which is the only reason it has ever been any use to anyone.

She finds the girl's wrist in the dark. Opens her hand against it. Closes it again.

The girl is doing four other things and does not look.

Good, thinks Alma, with the last of the dry practical part of her, the part that took in seams and left them deep and never once said

thank you for a blind hem. Don't look. You will only ask what it is, and then I will have to tell you, and then you will have that as well.

She goes on holding the girl's hand.

Somewhere in the following two minutes, without any of the ceremony that people who have not been present imagine, Alma Hallett stops.

The hand in the girl's hand stays warm for a while afterward, in the specific narrowing way that it does, and the girl keeps talking to her about rain, and sheets, and a song neither of them ever learned the name of.

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

The apprenticeship.

Year two, and the method turns — or perhaps it was always this shape and she is only now developed enough to see it.

He begins asking her to teach the exercises back to him. To put the stones into his hands and describe his own borders to him while he holds them. It is presented as pedagogy. You learn a language by speaking it.

She accepts the framing for four months, and then the old cold triage-voice — the one that has been reliably right about rooms for thirteen years and has been quiet since the collapse — produces a single clear reading:

Every exercise he has ever framed as being for her benefit produces, without exception, an outcome that serves him.

She does not act on it. She checks it the way she was trained to check things: she runs it again the following week, and the week after, and it comes back the same both times.

What ends it is smaller than any of that. One evening he refers to her practice — hers, the thing she walked in the door already doing — as something she learned here. Not unkindly. Not even deliberately. He says it the way a man says a thing he has believed so long that the believing has worn smooth.

She leaves on an ordinary Tuesday. No scene. She simply does not go back, and two days later, then two weeks, the absence starts to feel less like avoidance and more like a diagnosis she is finally willing to write down herself.

She keeps the word married. She has decided she is allowed. He did not invent it either.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

Seven years before.

The hands come back wrong.

Not damaged. Every scan is clean, every nerve conduction study is boringly normal, and three separate consultants tell her, with the particular gentleness they reserve for people whose problem is not in the part they can photograph, that there is nothing physically wrong with her hands.

What is wrong with her hands is that they no longer report temperature in a way she can use. Cold arrives as pressure. Warm arrives, sometimes, as nothing at all. A cup of tea and a cup of water are two objects of identical character. She finds this out in a kitchen at two in the morning and stands there for a long time holding both.

And underneath that, worse, the thing she does not have a word for yet: she has stopped being reliably able to say when she is. Not amnesia. The opposite. Too much availability. She reaches for a Tuesday and gets four of them, from four different years, all equally present, none of them labelled.

She works it out alone, on her kitchen floor, over eleven months.

The discovery is not mystical and she has never once described it as such. It is this: cold is the only signal that still arrives on time. Warmth is contaminated — warmth is where the other years live, warmth is the trapdoor — but cold comes in clean, now, current, undeniable. If she puts something cold against her skin and attends to it properly, the year resolves.

She uses, in order: a spoon. A window. A bottle from the fridge. A tile.

It is worth being exact about what the eleven months are like, because she has never been exact about it with anyone and because the phrase losing track of time does not begin to cover it.

It is not that she forgets. It is that everything is equally available. She reaches for a Tuesday and gets four Tuesdays, from four different years, arriving at the same volume with no labels on them,

and she has to sit down and work out which one is current by a process of elimination that can take, on a bad morning, six or seven minutes. She learns to check the date on a newspaper before she trusts a single thing her own head tells her about when she is.

Some of it is funny, in the way that only the person it is happening to finds funny. She rings her sister to ask about a school thing and it turns out the school thing was two years ago and the child in question is at a different school. She buys food for a person who stopped living with her in February. She catches herself walking toward a station she has not worked at since she was twenty-six.

Most of it is not funny.

The worst of it is not the confusion, which she can manage, but the arrivals. She will be doing something ordinary — folding something, standing at the window — and the air will change temperature, and she will be back in the void with her arm at an angle, entirely, in full, not as a memory but as an event happening now, for between four and ninety seconds. The clinical word for this is one she knows perfectly well and refuses to use about herself, which she is aware is the least intelligent thing about her.

She stops working. She does not resign; she simply stops going, and lets the service conclude, over several months, with a lot of paperwork and two uncomfortable meetings, that she has become a woman who cannot be relied upon to know what day it is, which is a fair assessment and which she does not contest.

Dara comes round twice in the first year and once in the second. The third visit is worse than the second and they both understand why and neither says it: he is carrying on. He is still doing the thing they used to do together and is therefore evidence, standing in her kitchen holding a mug, of what she is no longer.

She works out the cold thing in month nine, on the floor, with a bottle from the fridge against her sternum, and she is not moved by the discovery. She is a practical woman having a practical result. What she thinks, sitting there with a cold bottle and a correct year, is not that she has been saved. It is that she has found an instrument, and that she had better now build the rest of it.

And then, in the pocket of a coat she has not worn since, a stone.

There are two of them. One is a fragment of somebody's building, scorched along one face, which she remembers picking up and has never understood why. The other is a small rose-coloured pebble worn smooth, with a shallow dish polished into one face by a thumb that was not hers, and she does not remember picking that one up at all.

She assumes, for seven years, that she must have.

CHAPTER TWENTY

Now.

Session eight, and he asks the question. They all ask it eventually, in one phrasing or another, usually around week seven, usually when they have stopped being frightened of her.

"Did this heal you? Or did you just get very good at hiding it?"

Reyhan could answer with the department line. She could answer with a decade of clinical distance.

Instead she says, "Do you want the long version?"

He says yes, and means it, and so for the first time in eight years — out loud, to another person, in order — she tells him about the forty minutes.

It takes most of an hour. She does not perform it. She tells it the way you would read out a list: the size of the void, the dust, the name, the agreement that nothing true gets said unless Alma says it first. The weather. The sheets. The song. The stove, and the pan, and the fact that both of them were thinking about their kitchens, which is either the worst thing about human beings or the best, and she has never been able to decide.

He does not write anything down. She notices that and is obscurely grateful.

She gets to minute thirty-three. Will you tell someone I wasn't on my own.

And then she stops, because her hands have gone cold.

Not the room. Not the stones, which are in the box, on the table, untouched for forty minutes. Her own hands, both of them, going cold from the wrist down, fast, the way they have gone cold perhaps nine times in eight years, always without warning and always — she understands this only now, with a clarity that arrives like a struck bell — always when she is close to something.

The body has filed it. The body has been holding it the entire time. And the body, which does not use language and has no interest in her schedule, has chosen this Thursday to hand it back.

"Reyhan," the client says, from a long way off.

"I need a minute."

He gives her a minute. He is, it turns out, good at that. It is the only useful thing anyone has done for her in eight years and he has no idea he is doing it.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

Now.

Here is what comes back, in Alma's voice, intact, in the dark behind her eyes, with a generator starting somewhere and running for four seconds and stopping:

I've had yours since the start.

And then, because the body files in bundles and not in items: You should know that. In case it matters later.

Reyhan sits on the floor of a quiet room in a building that is not falling down, with a man she is being paid by watching her from four feet away, and does the arithmetic she has managed not to do for eight years.

She had assumed she was the one holding on. She has assumed it so continuously, and built so much on top of it, that the assumption long ago stopped being a thought and became a floor. Every session in this room proceeds from it. The whole practice proceeds from it. She is the one who reaches into the dark and holds on, and other people are the ones who need holding, and the arrangement is clean, and she is paid, and nobody in eight years has ever once been asked to hold her.

An eighty-year-old woman with a floor on top of her, thirty-four minutes into dying, spent the strength she had left warming the hands of a stranger who was too busy to notice, and then told her so, plainly, and flagged it — in case it matters later — and the stranger said okay.

And the stone. The rose stone. The one with a thumb-dish polished into it by a thumb that was not hers, that she has told herself for seven years she must have picked up.

Minute thirty-seven. A small movement. A transfer. A hand opening against her wrist and closing again.

She was given it.

Reyhan puts both hands flat on the mat, because they are shaking, and because putting your hands flat on the floor is the first thing

she teaches and it turns out to work, and she cries — not the decorous kind, not the kind she would permit in this room, the other kind, the kind that comes up out of the chest in a way that is frankly humiliating in front of a client and which she does not stop.

She has spent eight years teaching strangers to generate their own warmth.

She has never once managed it herself. Not once. Not in eight years. The warmth in her hand has been Alma's the entire time, handed over in the thirty-seventh minute by a dying woman with nothing left to give and no reason to give it, and Reyhan has been carrying it around in a lacquered box and charging people four hundred a session to hold it.

The client, who has understood none of this and all of it, says nothing at all.

He simply sits in it — genuinely, finally, unrehearsed — and she recognises the exact expression on his face, because she wore it once herself, in a room with no furniture, in front of an east-facing window, a very long time ago, and because she wore it once before that, in the dark, with a floor on top of her, and did not know what it was.

CHAPTER TWENTY-TWO

Now.

Alone, after the last client of the year, Reyhan sits on the floor mat with both stones in her open palms.

The black one is cold. It is always cold. It is a piece of a building that fell down and it has never once told her anything except the year, which is all she has ever asked of it, and it has never once been wrong.

The rose one is warm. It has been warm for years. She has held it perhaps four thousand times and assumed, in the unexamined way a person assumes the floor, that the warmth was coming from her.

She knows better now, and it does not help, and she has decided that not helping is not the same as not mattering.

She thinks about the word she kept. Married — two things that only make sense in relation to each other. She had always taken it to mean the stones. It does not mean the stones. It has never meant the stones. It means a building and a woman, which came down on her in the same hour and have been in the same room ever since, and cannot be told apart, and will not be separated by anything she is able to do about it.

She will tell someone Alma was not on her own.

She has told nobody for eight years. Not out of neglect — out of arithmetic. She never learned a surname. She had thirty-nine minutes with a woman and she used them on the weather, and by the time it occurred to her that a surname was a thing a person might need, there was no longer anybody to ask, and the asking would have required explaining why, and she had not yet understood why.

It is a small word. Four or five letters, probably. It was available for the whole forty minutes, free, for nothing, in exchange for a single question she did not think to put, and it has been unavailable ever since, and will be for the rest of her life.

She thinks she will start with the client. He is not the right person. There is no right person. He is the person who sat in it.

Then, because her hands have been doing this for twenty years and have never once asked her permission, she turns the rose stone over.

And finds, with her thumb, what has been there the entire time: not one hollow but two. A deep one, worn smooth and bright, and beside it and at a slightly different angle, fainter, smaller, a second.

She sits with that for a long while.

She will never know whose they were. She works out, in about four seconds, because she is a woman who reads geometry off objects for a living, everything the stone is capable of telling her: that two people carried it, that one of them had smaller hands, that it took decades, and that by the time it reached her it had been warm continuously for longer than she has been alive.

Outside, it is raining, the way it was raining two days before everything came apart, and inside, in a room with one amber lamp, a woman who has finally learned to read her own pulse again holds two stones, one cold and one warm, and calls them, silently, by the only name that was ever entirely hers.

GLOSSARY

Anahita [aa-naa-HEE-taa] — Ancient Iranian goddess of the waters, of healing and of wisdom, whose name carries the sense of the undefiled.

Asha [AA-shaa] — Avestan, truth, right order. The Zoroastrian principle of the truth that holds a structure together, as against the lie that costs nothing to tell.

Reyhan does not live her life in order. A stranger's grip, cold stone against skin, a certain slant of afternoon light — any of them is a trapdoor into another year of it.

She teaches the powerful to read their own bodies. Two stones, one pink and one black, one for the front border and one for the back. The cold comes first, because cold is the one fact a body cannot argue with.

Her new client has mastered everything except himself. The sessions are half seduction and half interrogation, and it is not always clear which of the two of them is being interrogated.

Underneath the work is an apprenticeship she has never described to anyone. Underneath that is a night in a collapsed building, forty minutes long, that her hands have never finished reporting.

The mind will lie to you for free. The body has to be paid first.

